

“acres of diamonds in my own backyard”—than any other human being on the face of this earth. You were right, Dr. Conwell!

Treasures False and True

I take special joy in telling you about the diamonds in my life and career, for I'm confident that each of you readers has also been blessed with diamonds, maybe many of them, if only you would stop and take a moment to count them. But too often, like the wealthy farmer in Dr. Conwell's parable, we search for illusory treasures and ignore the real ones that lie right beneath our feet. (Note the *we*—I'm as guilty as the next person!)

So I have indeed been given enough—enough diamonds (and hearts) to live a wonderful life, one that I hope has been useful to a family, a firm, an industry, even a society. But during these early years of the twenty-first century, I've developed a profound concern that our society is moving in the wrong direction, a concern so beautifully expressed in David Brooks's epigraph that begins this book. I'm guessing that Kurt Vonnegut and Joe Heller would share that view. While on Shelter Island they were talking about “enough” in the context of money and investments, their work held up a mirror to our entire society that reflected some of the absurdities and inequities that we've come to accept and take for granted.

In our financial system, we focus our expectations on the returns that the financial markets may deliver, ignoring the exorbitant costs extracted by our financial system, the excessive taxes engendered by record levels of speculative trading, and inflation borne of a government that spends (our) money beyond its means, grossly devastating these returns. We engage in the folly of short-term speculation and eschew the wisdom of long-term investing. We ignore the real diamonds of simplicity, seeking instead the illusory rhinestones of complexity.

In business, we place too much emphasis on what can be counted and not nearly enough on trusting and being trusted. When we should be doing exactly the opposite, we allow—indeed we almost